

A Resource-Efficient Hardware Accelerator for Lossless Image Compression Based on the Walsh–Hadamard Transform

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I. INTRODUCTION

Modern high-frame-rate camera systems, such as those deployed in intelligent vehicles and satellite imaging, generate massive volumes of data that must be processed and stored with minimal latency. In many of these edge-computing scenarios, lossless compression is essential because the uncertainty introduced by quantization noise in lossy systems is often inadmissible for maintaining system robustness or meeting legal requirements [7]. Implementing these codecs in real-time at the edge is a critical challenge, as embedded video processors must handle high-speed transform computations while operating under strict limitations regarding hardware area, power consumption, and thermal dissipation [11].

Transform methods are a fundamental component of image compression because they decorrelate spatial data before encoding, concentrating information into a smaller number of coefficients. Among these, the Walsh-Hadamard Transform (WHT) is particularly attractive for hardware implementations due to its significant computational advantages over sinusoidal transforms like the DFT or DCT. Because the WHT kernel matrix consists entirely of integer values of +1 and -1, the transform can be implemented very efficiently using only additions and subtractions, thereby eliminating the need for costly and time-consuming multipliers [1], [4].

Despite its advantages, state-of-the-art literature reveals limitations in existing solutions, which are frequently optimized for lossy applications or general neural network acceleration

rather than resource-efficient lossless compression. For example, some high-throughput WHT-based architectures are designed for signal processing but rely on 32-bit floating-point arithmetic, which is not ideal for exact, low-resource lossless operation [1]. Conversely, other lossless approaches, such as those based on the JPEG-LS standard, provide competitive compression but often do not leverage the unique hardware-friendly properties of the WHT [7].

In this paper, we propose a resource-efficient integer/reversible WHT accelerator specifically designed for low-latency lossless compression. Our main contributions are:

- An optimized (integer/reversible) WHT architecture that ensures mathematically exact data reconstruction for lossless applications.
- The development of a flexible design modeled at a high level (SystemC/HLS), allowing for rapid design space exploration and the generation of parallel-pipeline layouts.
- A comprehensive evaluation on FPGA hardware to verify performance metrics, demonstrating improvements in throughput and area efficiency compared to existing implementations.

The remainder of this paper presents the *Background and Related Work*, providing a review of the WHT mathematical foundations and current hardware implementation strategies. The *Proposed Solution / Architecture*, describing our high-level modeling approach and the specific hardware structures of the integer WHT accelerator. *Results and Analysis*, detailing the experimental setup and providing a comparative analysis of our results on FPGA. And finally, the *Conclusions and Future Work*, which summarizes our findings and outlines potential avenues for further optimization in real-time edge compression.

II. BACKGROUND AND RELATED WORK

The Walsh–Hadamard transform (WHT) decomposes a signal into Walsh basis functions whose values are restricted to ± 1 . For a signal of 2^n samples the transform is a multiplication by the $2^n \times 2^n$ Hadamard matrix, and since its entries are ± 1 it can be evaluated with additions and subtractions alone. The fast WHT (FWHT) lowers the arithmetic cost from $O(N^2)$ to $O(N \log_2 N)$ through Cooley–Tukey-style factorizations [1], and its parallel-pipeline hardware implementations follow processor structures first developed for the fast Fourier transform [14].

Exact reconstruction is what keeps the WHT from being lossless. Its inverse normalizes by the transform size N , a division that integer arithmetic cannot represent exactly, so a direct WHT loses information over a round trip through the transform and its inverse. Integer, reversible formulations remove this limitation. The unified lossless WHT (ULWHT) recovers the original data exactly while lowering the per-coefficient entropy of natural images [2], and a lossless two-dimensional WHT has also been derived [3]. For hardware there is a caveat: the one-dimensional lossless WHT still contains multiplications, and making it fully multiplier-free needs a more elaborate construction [3].

Two closely related solutions provide reproducible results with public code, and between them they cover both sides of the problem. One is an FPGA WHT accelerator: a configurable parallel-pipeline FWHT produced by high-level synthesis, with its HLS source openly released [1]. The other is a parallel lossless compressor for raw Bayer images on an FPGA-based high-speed camera that sustains 40.1 Gbit/s at 320 MHz on a Zynq UltraScale+ device, using adaptive Golomb–Rice coding and a public reference implementation [5]. One supplies the transform, the other a low-latency lossless pipeline; bringing the two together is the open problem.

Five further works address parts of the problem. In hardware, a multiplier-free WHT running at 162 MHz takes the place of the Photo Core Transform in JPEG XR [4], an FPGA JPEG 2000 accelerator performs on-board lossless compression [6], and an ANS-based coder reduces the complexity of JPEG-LS [7]. The integer lossless WHT formulations achieve bit-exact compression but stop at the algorithmic level, with no hardware realization [2], [3]. Earlier WHT processors based on distributed arithmetic [11], the sequency-ordered complex Hadamard transform [12], and a radix-2 Walsh–Hadamard–Fourier pipeline [13] were built for high throughput and small area, drawing on the low complexity of the ± 1 kernel [8].

The WHT also appears outside compression, in image watermarking [15], ultrasonic coded excitation [9], and the simulation of quantum algorithms [10]. Across this literature we found no hardware accelerator from the past decade that performs lossless, WHT-based compression of high-frame-rate image streams. The reproducible accelerators cover either the transform [1] or the lossless coding [5], and the lossless integer WHT has stayed at the algorithmic level [2], [3]. Closing this gap is the aim of the present work.

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